



DEPARTMENT OF POLITICAL SCIENCE

COURSE REPORT FOR FIRST CYCLE COURSES IN POLITICAL SCIENCE

The aim of the course report is to demonstrate responsiveness towards the students' views, guarantee the quality of the course, and stimulate subject related and pedagogical development. The report should have a forward-looking focus and be based on the course coordinator's own reflections and input received from students (individually or in groups), teaching staff, education administrators, and the study counsellor, as well as the course evaluation.

Course name: Conflict and Conflict Management Course code: SK1127 Semester: Fall Semester 2025 (HT2025)	Course coordinator (name and e-mail address): Magnus Lundgren (magnus.lundgren@gu.se)
Brief description of course content and structure	The course is the second course on the International Politics track in the second year of the "Statsvetarprogrammet". It was offered for the third time. The course provides an introductory study of armed conflict in international politics, aiming to equip students with theoretical and empirical knowledge about the causes, dynamics, and resolution of armed conflicts. The course included seven lectures (reduced from eight due to budgeted hours) and two seminars structured as interactive simulations (a bargaining simulation and a mediation exercise). The readings combined Levy & Thompson's "Causes of War" and Blattman's "Why We Fight", along with supplementary articles. Examination consisted of seminar participation (reflective essays), a research paper (3,000 words, 2-stage submission), and—new this semester—an oral exam focused on the research paper. The oral exam was introduced to verify authorship, support assessment, and reinforce learning, in response to the increasing use of AI among students. Three teachers were involved: Magnus Lundgren (lectures, coordination, and one seminar group) and Jan Rustemeyer and Leonie Reicheneder (one seminar group each, including assessment).
Completion rate and grades	The course had 33 registered students. Of these, 30 received a final grade: 21 G (pass) and 9 VG (pass with distinction).
General and specific impressions of the course	The main structural changes compared to the previous semester were the addition of a 10–12 minute oral examination focused on the research paper, and a reduction from eight to seven lectures (the "future of war" lecture was put on pause due to a reduction in budgeted hours). The oral exam was an overall positive experience. Students came prepared and many appreciated the opportunity to discuss their work with a teacher. From a teacher perspective, the

	oral exam was a very useful complement to the written paper, but 10–12 minutes proved somewhat too short to reliably evaluate the full grading criteria. The reduction to seven lectures did not appear to significantly affect the course. Overall, the course functioned well both organizationally and substantively.
Students' general impressions of the course	The course received very positive feedback, with 100% of respondents rating it favorably (86.7% "Very Good", 13.3% "Rather Good"; 15 out of 34 students responded, a 44% response rate). Students described the course as "incredible", "my favorite course in the Statsvetarprogrammet", and "very informing, good study pace." 73.3% reported learning "a great deal" and 26.7% "a fair amount". No student reported learning little or nothing.
Students' impressions of specific elements of the course	Lectures were rated favorably by 100% of respondents (92.9% "Very Good"), with students highlighting their structure and the engaging warm-up questions. Teachers were also rated favorably by 100% (93.3% "Very Good"). The literature was rated favorably by 100% (60% "Very Good", 40% "Rather Good"). The seminars were rated favorably by 100% (53.3% "Very Good", 46.7% "Rather Good"); students described the simulations as "innovative" and "more telling on both theory and practice than I anticipated," though some found the second seminar's instructions somewhat unclear. The research paper was rated favorably by 93.3% (66.7% "Very Good", 26.7% "Rather Good"), with students appreciating the topic flexibility but some wanting more time and feedback during the writing process. Several noted that having the second seminar overlap with the research paper deadline created stress. Course organization was rated favorably by 100% (80% "Very Good"). Regarding workload, 60% found it "OK", while 33% found it somewhat or much too demanding, primarily due to reading volume and simultaneous assignments.
Impression of any epiphany moments that the students have experienced during the course	The causes of war, particularly bargaining theory and systemic explanations, were the most frequently cited as engaging topics. The bargaining simulation stood out as a moment where theory came alive. The warm-up questions at the start of lectures were highlighted by students as helping them actively engage with the material.
Impressions of students' and teachers' views on the administration of the course, incl. Canvas	80% of students rated the course organization, including Canvas, as Very Good. Students found information easy to access and described the Canvas page as "really, really clear." Minor confusion arose about reflective essay deadlines (working days vs. calendar days), which was quickly clarified. Several students suggested reorganizing the final two weeks to reduce overlap between seminar 2 and the research paper deadline. From the teachers' perspective, administration functioned smoothly.
Ideas of potential changes for the next round	The oral exam will be extended from 10–12 to 15 minutes per student, to allow for a more thorough and reliable assessment against the grading criteria. Relatedly, the weighting of the written and oral components in the overall grade will be calibrated. There

	will be minor updates to the article readings. Several students suggested reducing the overlap between seminar 2 and the research paper deadline. Within the calendar constraints of a short and intensive course, the schedule will be optimized to reduce this overlap where possible.
Ideas of long-term and/or more comprehensive changes	The main long-term priority is to continue adapting the course to an AI-dominated environment; this concerns primarily the examination format, where the oral exam is a key part of the response. In addition, the ambition is to increase interactive components in the course over time.
Other comments	The course continues to receive strong evaluations across all three semesters it has been offered. The introduction of the oral exam was a significant pedagogical development this semester, and the positive reception from both students and teachers supports its continuation and further refinement.

From the course evaluation question: "Overall, how do you assess the course?"

	HT24	VT25	HT25
Means	4.85	4.94	4.94

Note: Five-point scale on which 1 corresponds to "Very bad" and 5 to "Very good".